

Treatment Alliance

Reference: Freeman R. A psychodynamic understanding of the dentist-patient interaction. British dental journal. 1999 May;186(10):503-6.

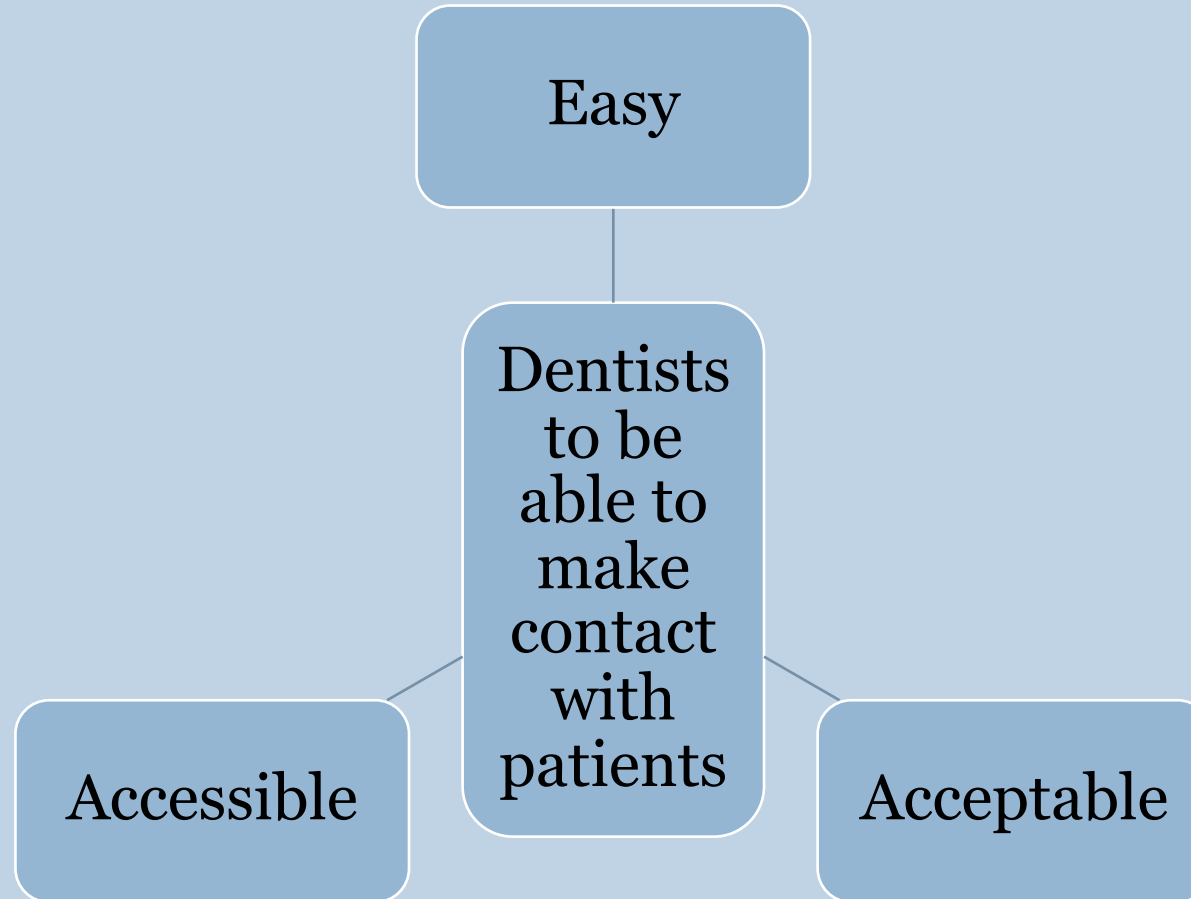


Lecture learning outcomes:

- Explain treatment alliance and its importance
- List the types of dentist patient relationship based on psychological explanation



Aim of continuous dental care



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For patients who are ‘Regular attenders’

- Dentists have been able to form and maintain a ‘treatment’ relationship.



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People are non-compliant

- Because they are too anxious, too impoverished and/or seem to be too disinterested to attend
- They are unable to use the dental care offered and provided by the dental team.



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Patient management

- Many ways and techniques in which dentists provide dental care for their patients.

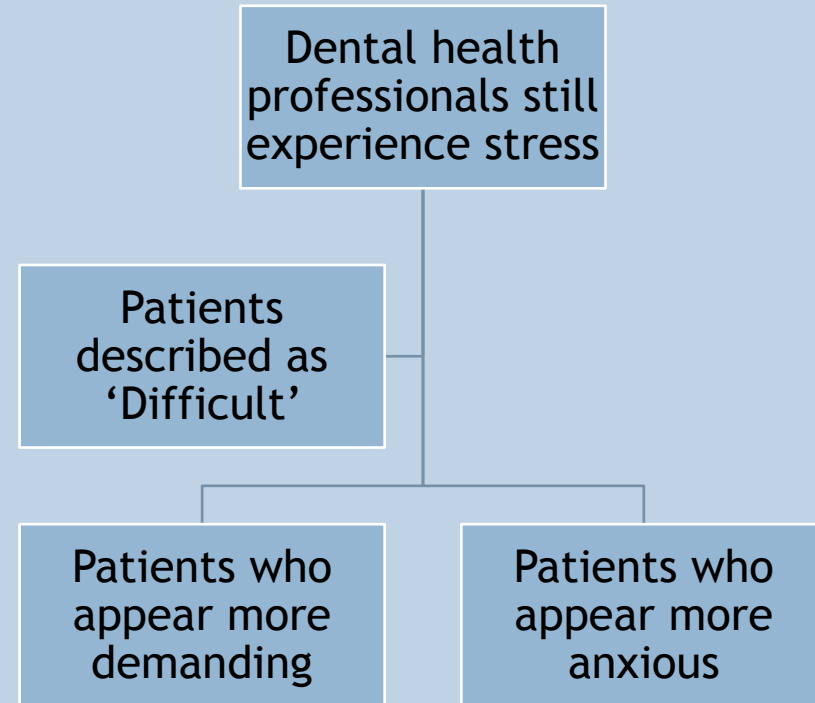


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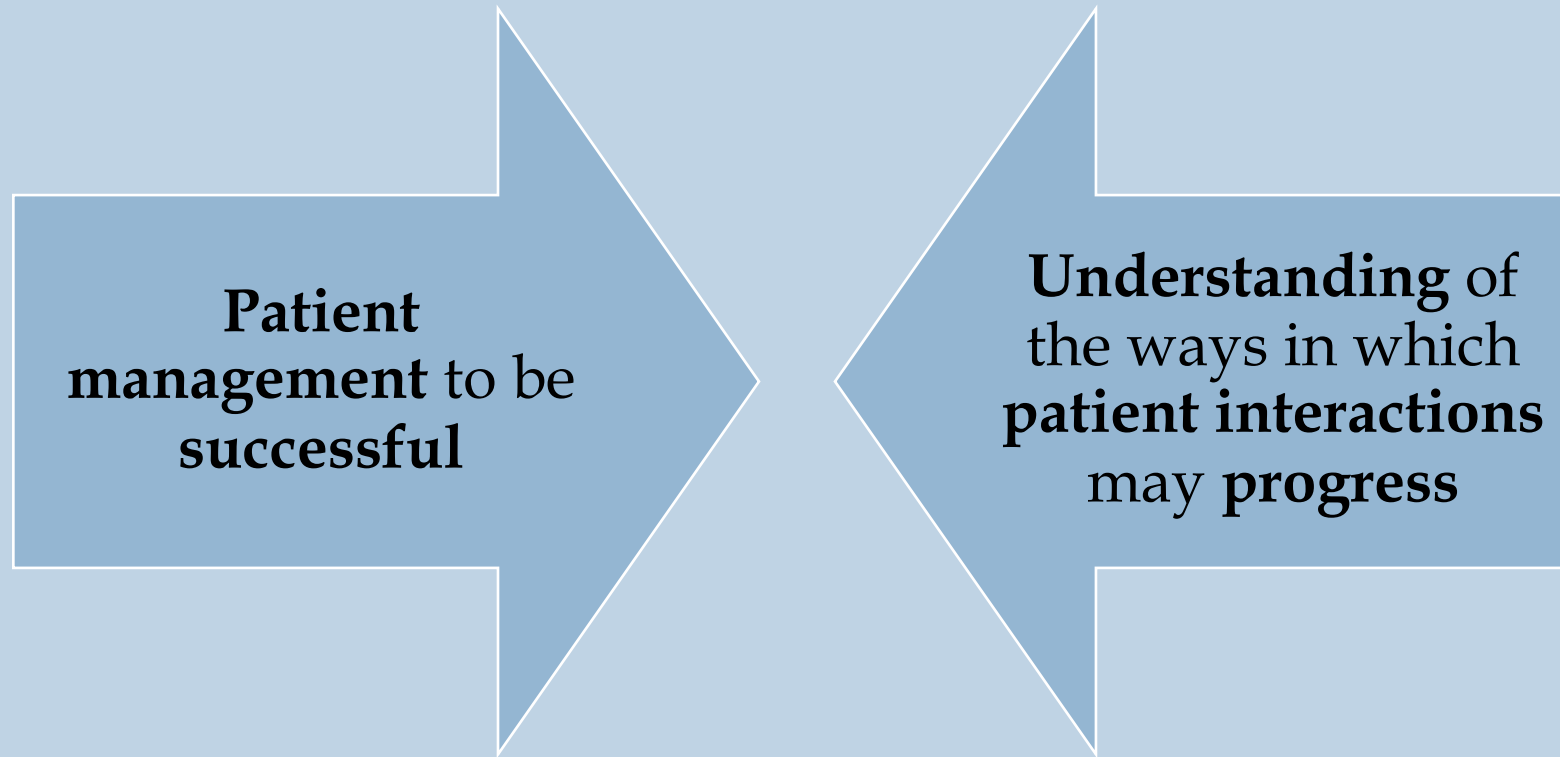


Methods of patient management

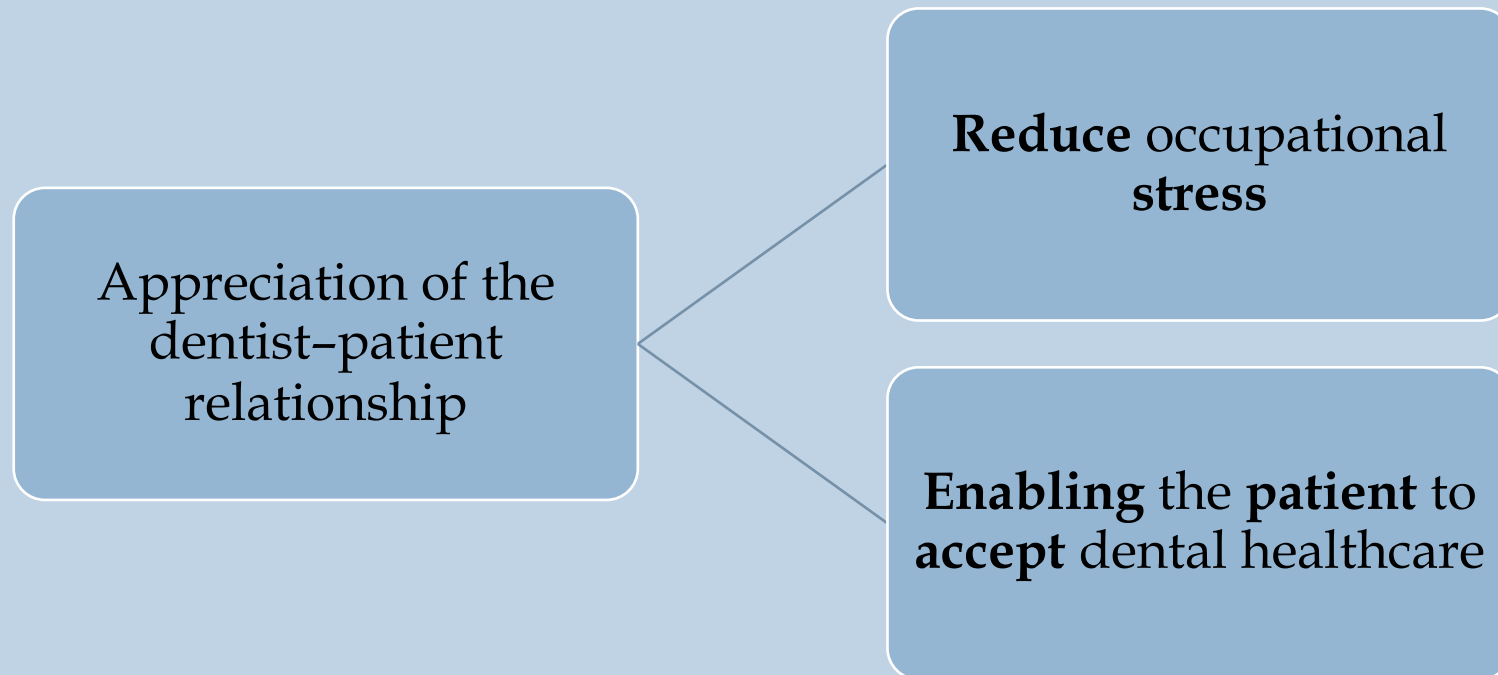
- Help to assist dentists in their work with patients by reducing stress.



Methods of patient management



Psychodynamic model



Psychodynamic viewpoint

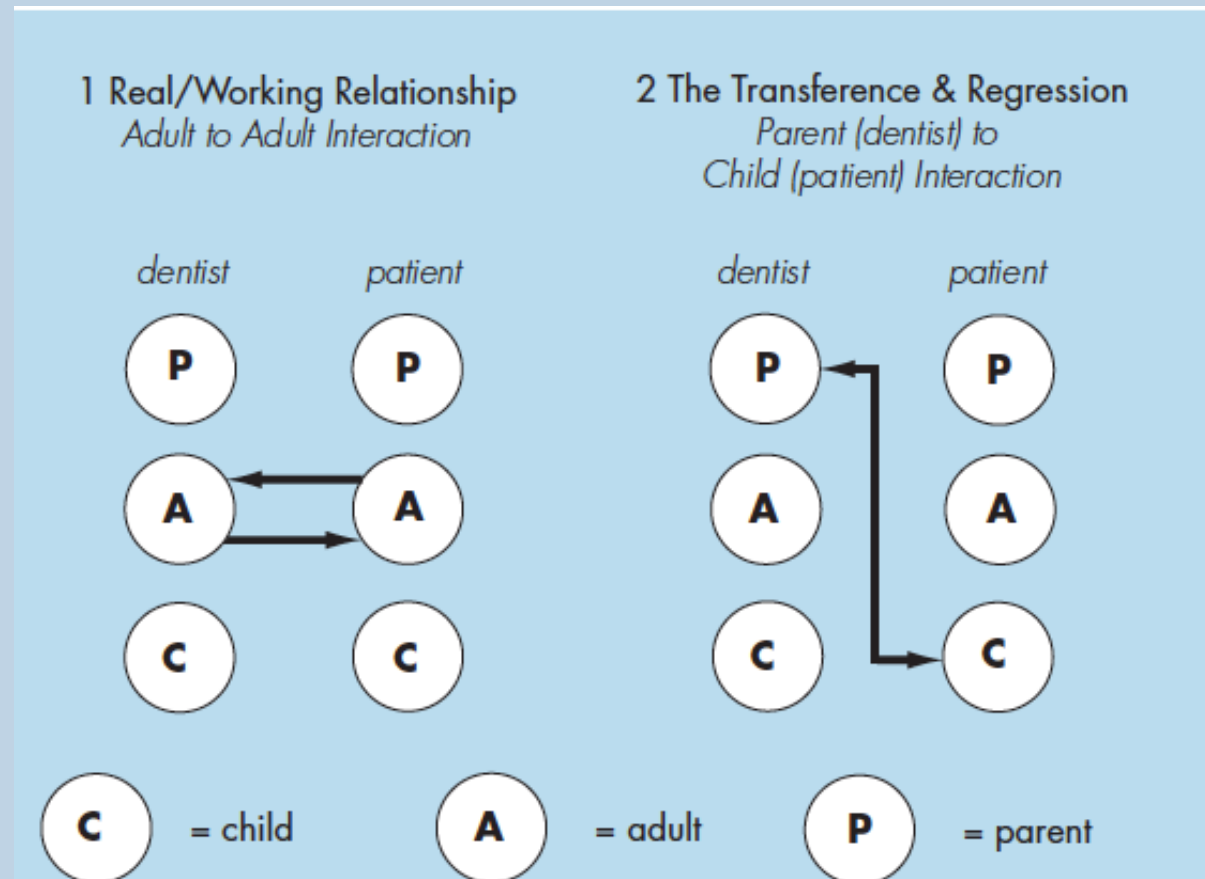
- Dental healthcare is a **2-person endeavour**.
- It is the **dentist working** with the **patient** and the **patient** being able to **accept** (use) the **work** (treatment) **offered** and **provided** by the dentist.



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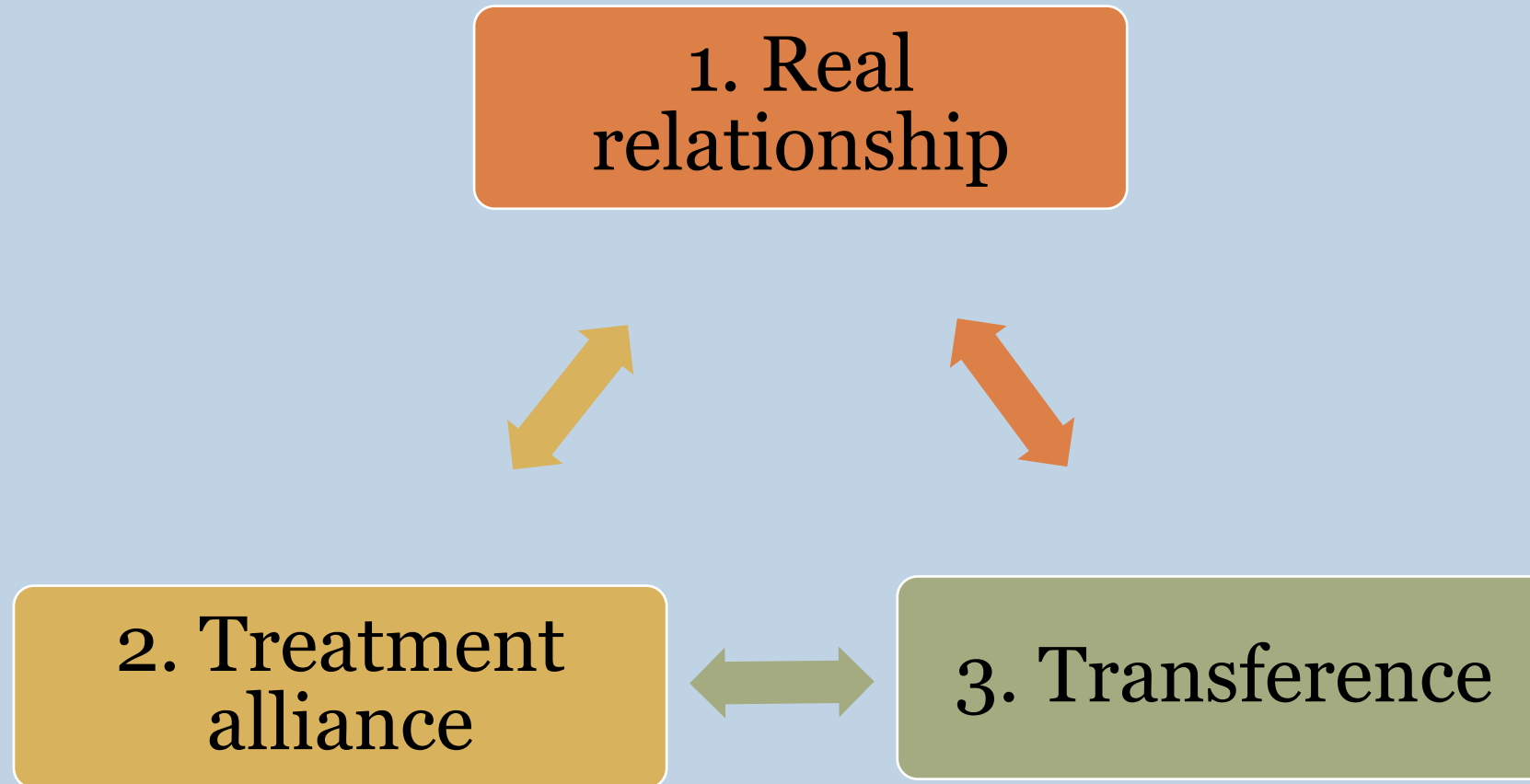
Psychological explanation of the dentist-patient relationship



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Aspects of the psychodynamic model

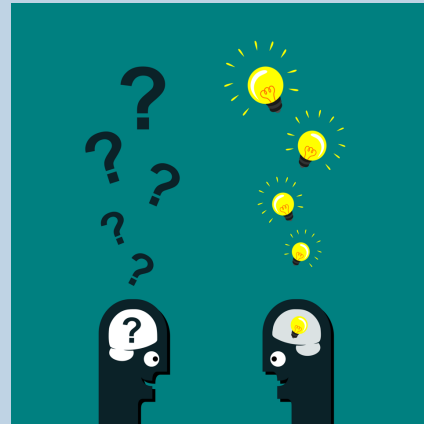


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Real relationship

- **Equal and unique relationship between two adults**
- Adult-to-adult equality of the relationship the **dentist will have been chosen by the patient** because of his **clinical attributes and skills**



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Case 1

- Mrs W, a 25 year old woman, had recently **moved to new town** and was looking for a **new dentist**. She had been very pleased with her previous dentist with whom she had been able to manage her considerable dental anxiety. She would have continued to see him but for her new location. It was just too far to travel. She had asked about a dentist at her place of work and had been told that the **dentist nearby** had a **good reputation**. Mrs W **decided** to make an **appointment**. This was based upon the dentist's **clinical reputation** and **patient management skills**.
- W's interaction with her new dentist is a good example of which aspect of psychodynamic model?



Case discussion

- Mrs W's interaction with her new dentist is a good example of the real relationship (Case 1). She experienced high dental anxiety and wished to find a dentist with good clinical as well as patient management skills. Her wish for a competent dentist was unaffected by her dental anxiety.



Treatment alliance

- Equal relationship between two adults
- It is not only a development of the real relationship but is affected by the patient's anxieties and concerns with regard to accepting dental treatment



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Treatment alliance

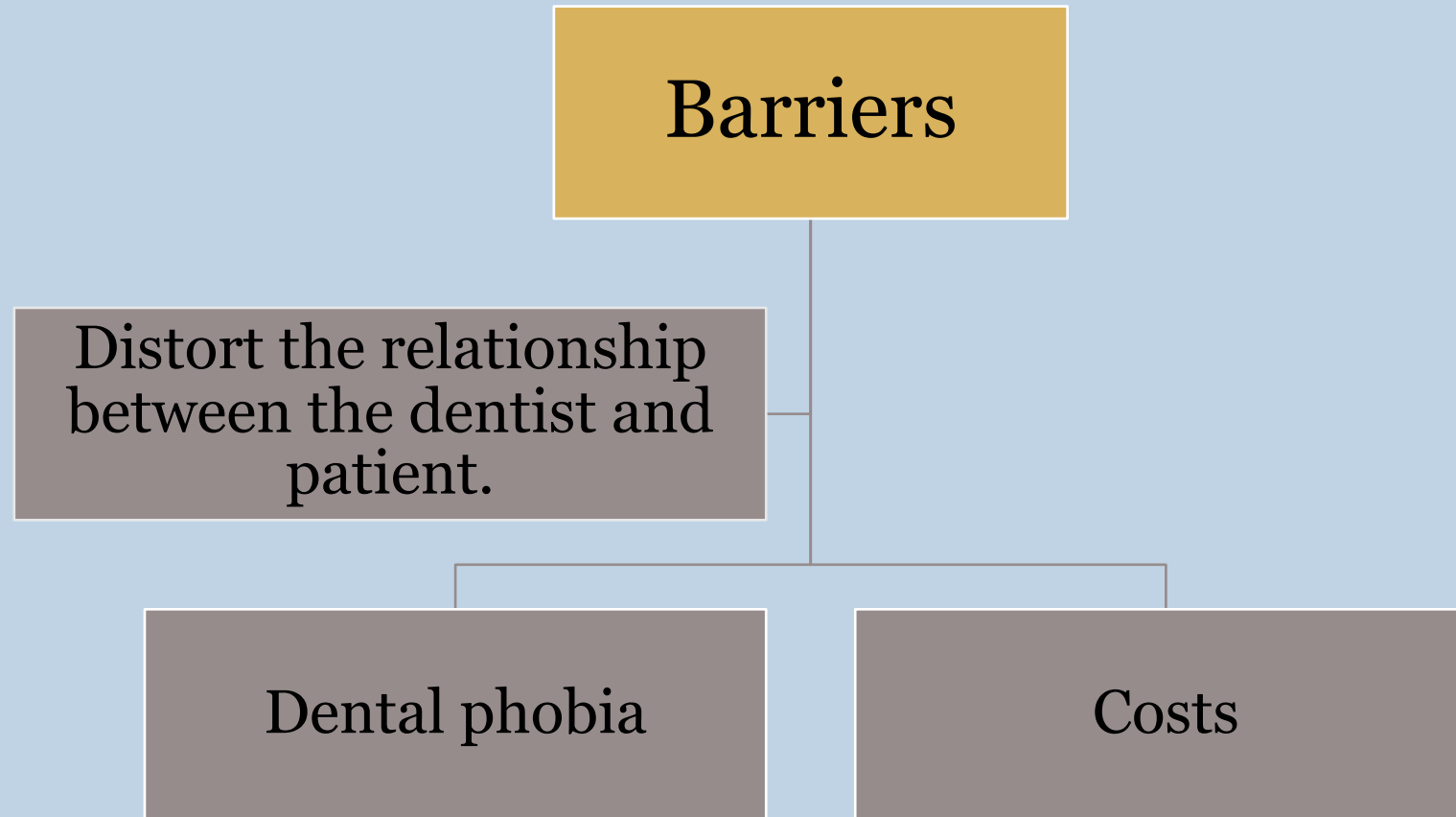
- The patient is unable to accept or use the treatment offered by the dentist.
- **Reason:** The intensity of anxiety, for instance, may render it impossible for the patient to depend upon, or align himself with, the dentist.



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Barriers to compliance in treatment alliance

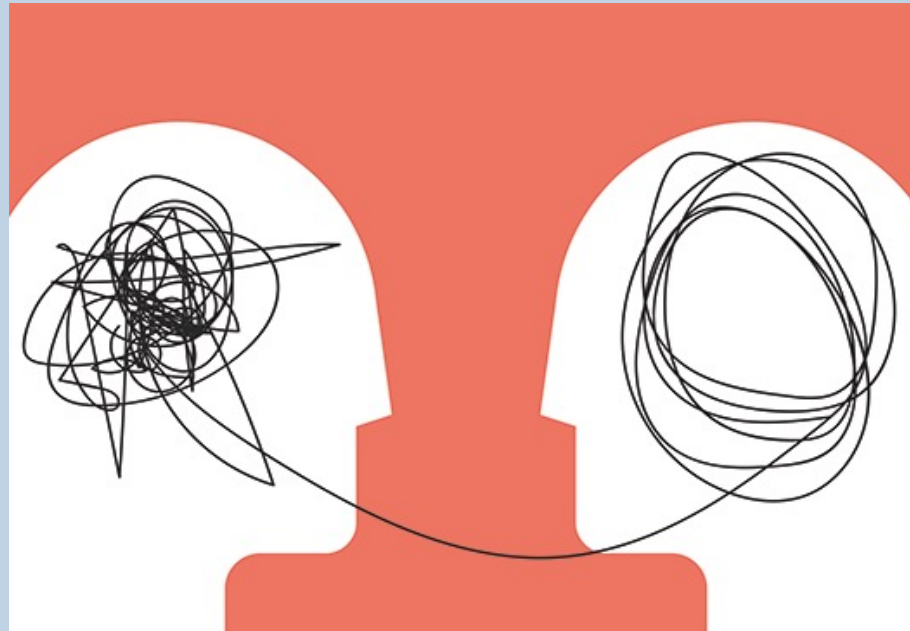


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Treatment alliance

- The patient's concerns and anxiety about dental treatment seem to **merge** with the dentist's clinical and patient management skills.



Case 2

- **Laura**, a 25-year-old woman attended for dental treatment. She was **anxious** and **delayed the start of treatment** by using every means available to her. Despite being **implored** (requested) by the **dentist** and the **nurse** she **finally refused** to have any **treatment** at all, becoming distressed and tearful. After Laura left the dentist complained ‘difficult patients!’. However on reflection he acknowledged how **uncomfortable he felt** in response to the **intensity of Laura’s anxiety**. When she came for the **next visit** he **talked** to her about her **fears and concerns** and Laura admitted that her anxiety had led to her being unable to sleep for nights. The dentist **discussed** with her **why she was so anxious** and subsequently by working together a **treatment alliance** was formed and together they were able to **formulate a treatment plan**.
- The example of Laura shows the intensity of the patients anxiety can make achievement of which aspect of psychodynamic model difficult for both patient and dentist?



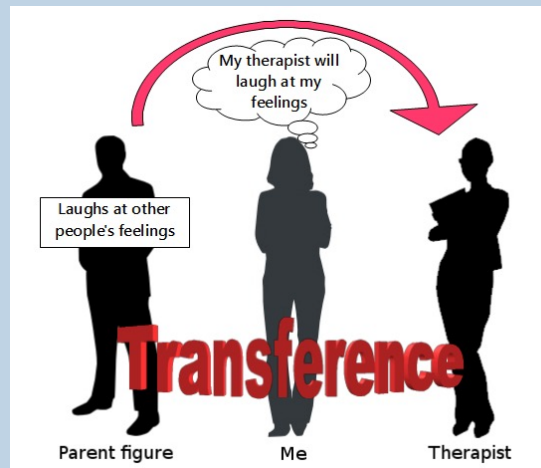
Case discussion

- Laura's anxiety was so intense that she was unable to depend upon the dentist (align herself with him) or use the dental care he was providing for her. However, Laura's anxiety also affected the dentist. He too became unable to function within the treatment alliance, describing her as 'difficult'. Only **after a realisation** as to the **inappropriateness of his reaction** to the patient was he able to make **adjustments and re-formulate** his treatment plans in **accordance to Laura's psychological and dental needs**.



Transference

- Transference **develops** with time.
- The transference **represents** the **past**.
- It is a **repetition** of **previously** emotionally important relationships which are **inappropriately imposed** by the **patient** upon the **dentist**.

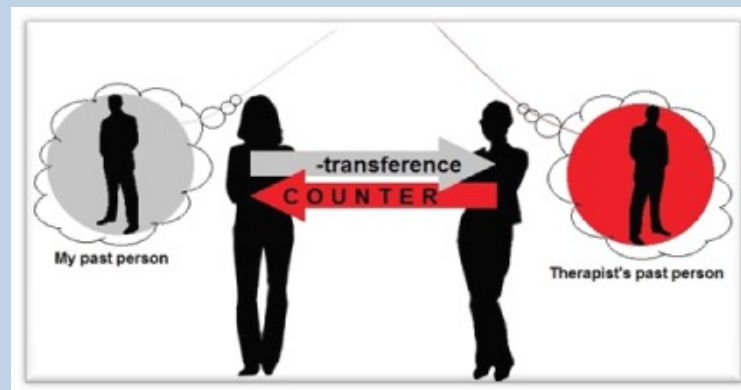


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Transference

- Within the transference the **adult patient** will **re-experience** childhood memories and fears.
- Intrinsically associated with **regression**.



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Regression

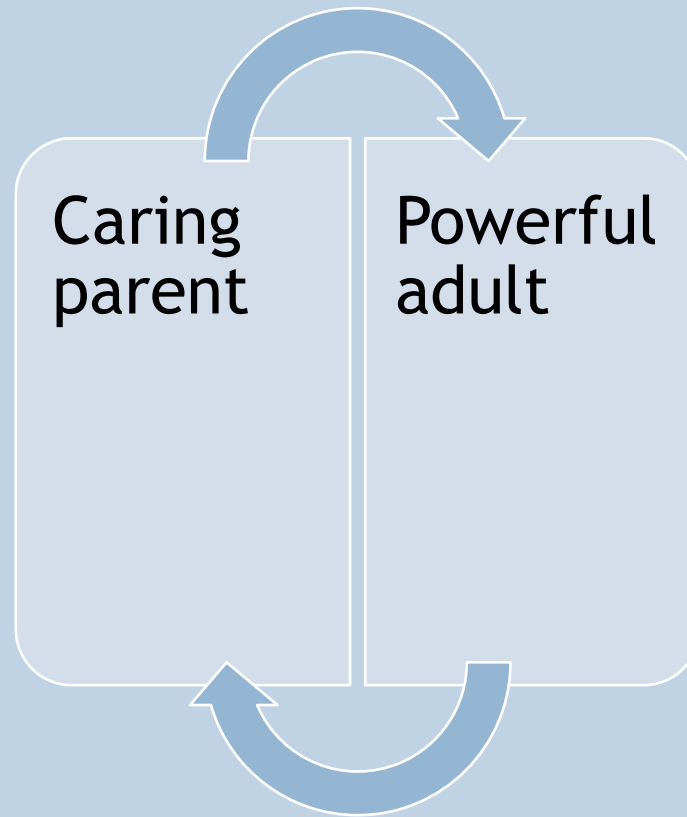
- Describes the **psychological state** of the **patients** as they change from being in an **emotionally controlled** to a **less well controlled emotional state**.
- The interaction is one between the **dentist** as ‘**parent**’ and **patient** as ‘**child**’



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Dentist may be perceived as



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Case 3

- **Mr B** was 55 years old. He was **successful** in his **professional life** and was considered to be assertive and impartial in his dealings with colleagues. Mr B was a **regular dental attender** despite being very **frightened** by the thought of **dental treatment**. While he **remained assertive** in his **dealings** outside the **dental surgery**, **inside** he admitted to such **anxiety** that he **felt helpless** like the **little boy** he once was. He **openly talked** of how he **relived a childhood dental experience** expecting each **filling** to be as **painful** as in the **past**.



Case discussion

- Mr B regressed from an **emotionally controlled state outside the dental surgery** to a **less well controlled emotional state inside** the dental surgery. The dentist's awareness of Mr B's feelings about dental treatment helped Mr B ventilate his concerns and anxieties. This was achieved because of the **treatment alliance** which **existed, outside the transference**. Mr B was able to use the information exchange with the dentist, together with the care offered by the dentist, as a result of the treatment alliance. The dentist had restored the adult-to-adult equality status in the dentist-patient relationship.



Applying the psychodynamic model to general practice (3 basic models dentist patient interaction)

Three basic models of the dentist–patient interaction				
Model	Dentist's role	Patient's role	Clinical application	Prototype of model
Activity–passivity	does something to the patient	receives the treatment	operative dental treatment	parent to child
Guidance–cooperation	tells the patient what to do	obeys accordingly	dental check-up appointment	parent to child
Mutual–participation	advises and negotiates with patient	patient in equal partner care	negotiation treatment or preventive plans	adult to adult

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The treatment session: an example of the activity–passivity model

- The **patient** must be **passive** and the **dentist** **active** so that dental treatment is possible.
- If the **treatment alliance** were **not** in operation the patient would be **unable** to accept dental care.



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Dental check up visit: an example of guidance-cooperation model

- Relationship between the dentist and the patient is one in which the dentist is the caring parent and the patient the cared-for child.



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Dental check up visit: an example of guidance-cooperation model

- The attendance of the patient reflects the real relationship and treatment alliance.
- The patient re-attends because of the care afforded to her by the dentist. This is a reflection of the real relationship between dentist and patient.
- Since the patient has been able to use the dentist's care by attending it also illustrates that the treatment alliance is operative



Case 4

- Mrs R attended for her usual **check-up visit**. She had **assumed** that **nothing was wrong** and was pleased when the dentist suggested that they should meet again in **12 months time**. However, the **dentist** noticed that a **cyst** at the **corner** of Mrs R's **eye** had become much larger since they had last met and **mentioned his concerns**. Mrs R got very **angry**. Nevertheless she **phoned** the **dentist** about 4 weeks later to **thank** him. She had acted upon his advice and **attended** the **eye department** as an **emergency**. They had **removed the lesion** which was subsequently shown to be a **lachrymal cyst**. Mrs R had been very worried about it and was now reassured. She **thanked** the **dentist** for his **interest** in her **general health**.



Case discussion

- Mrs R attended for her routine appointment. She thought as the **dentist** thought that there would be **nothing to do**. She also knew that something had to be done with her eye. **Mrs R's response** to her **dentist's concern** may be explained using the **guidance cooperation** formulation. While acknowledging that she overcame a great anxiety she was, nevertheless, able to act on the dentist's guidance by cooperating and attending the eye department. She was able to do so because of the **treatment alliance** and her ability to use the information and care provided by the dentist.



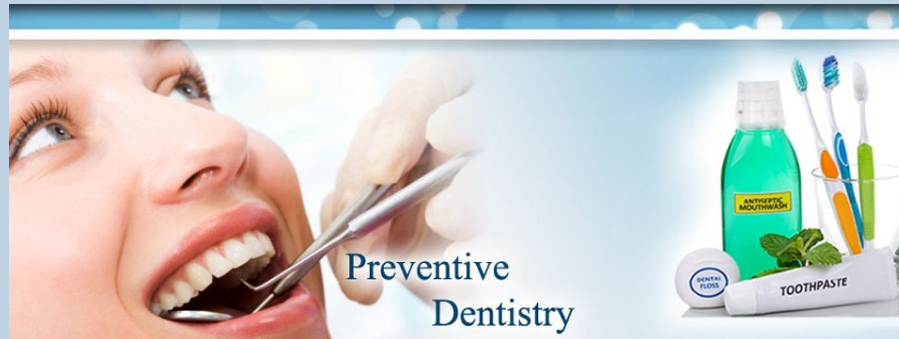
Negotiating preventive health goals: an example of the mutual-participation model

- In the mutual-participation formulation **two adults** are working together for **common dental health goals**.
- Suggesting that **preventive dental care** must be a **two-person endeavour** between adults.



Negotiating preventive health goals: an example of the mutual-participation model

- This is achieved by **encouraging** the **patient** to be active and to use the information exchange to **help her to participate** as well as enabling her to **take responsibility** for her own dental health.
- Techniques such as **motivational interviewing** may be used in this model.

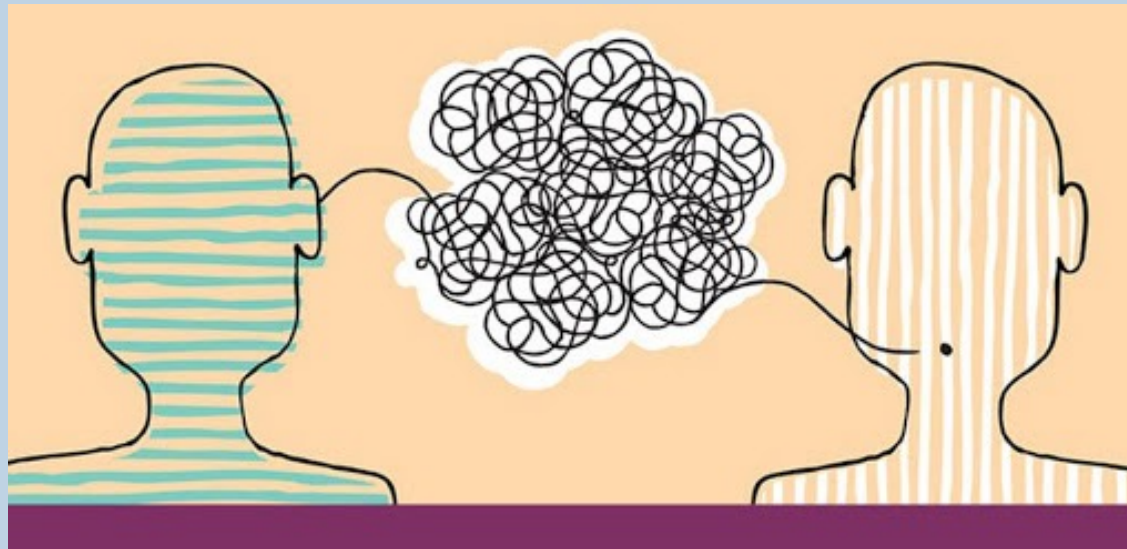


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What is Motivational Interviewing (MI)?

- Is a method of communication
- Style or method of counselling patients



Conclusion

- Dental healthcare which acknowledges the role of the real relationship, the treatment alliance and the transference within a **dynamic framework**, will maintain the **equality** of the **dentist patient relationship**.



Thank you

